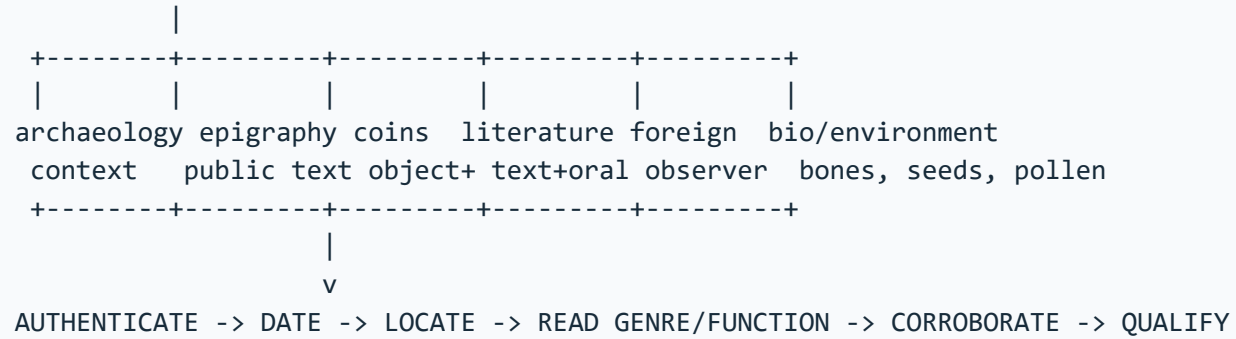


ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/9: The source universe: trace to reconstruction

SOURCES OF ANCIENT INDIA



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/9: Archaeology: context before object

SURVEY -> SITE -> GRID/TRENCH -> STRATIGRAPHY -> ASSEMBLAGE -> INTERPRETATION

|
v

Law of superposition: an undisturbed lower layer is relatively earlier.

Artefact alone: weak provenance | artefact in sealed context: stronger association

Industry = recurrent technique/tool set; culture = patterned material assemblage.

Intrusion, redeposition and mixed layers can break a simple sequence.

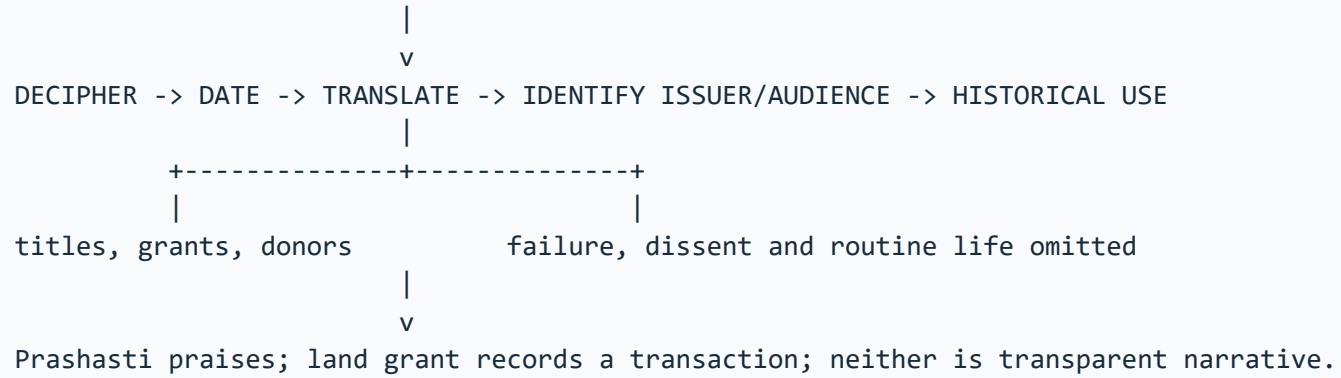
ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/9: Dating ladder: precision with error bars

RELATIVE DATE	ABSOLUTE/CHRONOMETRIC DATE
stratigraphy -> seriation -> typology	radiocarbon -> calibrated range
cross-dating -> association	TL/OSL -> last heating or light exposure
	dendrochronology where wood survives
+-----+-----+	
v	

A date belongs to a sample and context, not automatically to an entire culture.
Report range, calibration and contamination risk; probability is not certainty.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/9: Inscriptions: public text under source criticism

MATERIAL + SCRIPT + LANGUAGE + FORMULA + FIND SPOT



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/9: Coins: object, text and economic instrument

COIN

- |-- metal, weight, fabric -> standard, mint practice, debasement
- |-- legend, script, title -> issuer and political idiom
- |-- iconography -> religious/royal representation
- |-- hoard/find context -> circulation, saving, frontier or crisis
- |-- overstrike/imitation -> succession, appropriation and contact
- |

+> LIMIT: coin abundance is not a direct graph of total prosperity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/9: Texts: genre, layer and transmission

BRAHMANICAL	BUDDHIST/JAINA	SANGAM	MANUSCRIPT STATE
Veda, epic, Purana	canon, commentaries	poems, anthologies	copied much later
ritual/norm/memory	doctrine/institution	genre-coded society	variant readings
+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+

v

Ask composition layer, redaction, audience and norm/practice gap before extracting fact.
Critical editions compare witnesses; they do not restore an uncontested original.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/9: Foreign, linguistic, visual and biological witnesses

FOREIGN ACCOUNT	LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE	MATERIAL/BIO ARCHIVE
selective itinerary	family/contact/loanword	monument, bone, seed, pollen
outsider categories	language is not race	context and preservation govern use
Megasthenes/Faxian/ Xuanzang/Periplus	retroflexion/contact	diet, disease, crop and environment
	+-----+	+-----+
	v	

Use each as an angled witness; triangulate before converting observation into structure.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/9: Triangulation and productive contradiction

QUESTION: urbanism / polity / trade / religion / social hierarchy

```
|
+--> text says X
+--> inscription records Y
+--> archaeology patterns Z
+--> scientific evidence dates the context
|
v
```

AGREEMENT strengthens; contradiction prompts genre, region and chronology checks.

VERDICT: independent convergence is stronger than repetition in one tradition.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/9: Source-based answer architecture: 10/15/20 marks

10 MARKS: identify source -> what it reveals -> named example -> one limitation

15 MARKS: classify sources -> compare powers -> triangulate a case -> qualify

20 MARKS: problem -> source matrix -> method/dating -> case clinics -> conflicts
-> silences/preservation -> reasoned verdict on confidence

EVIDENCE SENTENCE: X indicates Y because Z; however, genre/context limits W.

Never end with all sources are important; state which source answers which question.